

Heuristic Evaluation

Structure of the individual report

Part I: Your Name

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Part II: Project Description

This project is a smartphone prototype for a hiking app that lets users check routes, read tips, navigate, and add comments.

Part III: Evaluation Execution

I evaluated the evaluation in person in the lab session. The domain name was hiking, and they provided their smartphone paper prototype. Two members of the group (one of them as the facilitator and the other as a computer) gave me three tasks, and a short explanation of the project, and the smartphone prototype screens. I went through each task step-by-step and compared the interface with Nielsen's heuristics while taking notes. The information they provided was clear enough to complete the evaluation.

Part IV: List of Violations

Report the heuristics' violations you identified. Each of them must be numbered sequentially, formatted as follow:

Issue 1. H1 Visibility of system status & H3 User control and freedom

- *Where: Task 1 – Saved Routes page*
- *What: In the flow diagram, it is not clear what happens when the user taps one of the saved routes (like "Route title 1"). The only defined path is the one that starts from the search box.*
- *Why: This uncertainty makes the user unsure about the result of their action (violating H1), and it also reduces their control because the next step of the interaction is not defined (violating H3).*
- *Severity: 3*

Issue 2. H2 Match between system and the real world

- Where: Task 1 – All tips page & Tip details page
- What: In the tips list, each item uses a red “user” icon, even though the tips are not related to user profiles. The same icon appears again in the tip details, but without any real user information.
- Why: The icon suggests something related to accounts or personal identity, which does not match the meaning of the tips. Since these tips describe hazards or warnings on the route, a hazard symbol or even a simple number would communicate the meaning much more clearly.
- Severity:2

Issue 3. H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design

- Where: Task 1 – All tips page
- What: The All-tips page shows all tips in the exact same style, with no grouping or clear structure. Everything looks similar and it’s hard to quickly spot what is important.
- Why: Because nothing is organized or separated, the page feels crowded and the user has to read each item one by one to understand what it is. A simple grouping or clearer visual differences would make the page much easier to scan.
- Severity:2

Issue 4. H5 Error prevention & H1 Visibility of system status

- Where: Task 2 – Navigation fork (STOP button)
- What: The “STOP” button is large and highlighted, but the prototype does not explain what it actually does. It is unclear whether it stops the navigation, cancels the route, or leads to another screen.
- Why: This ambiguity increases the chance of user mistakes (H5), because pressing the button might trigger an unwanted action. It also violates visibility (H1), since the system gives no feedback about what will happen after tapping it.
- Severity: 3

Issue 5. H10 Help and documentation

- Where: Task 2 – Comment details page
- What: The star rating on the Comment details page is shown without any explanation. It is not clear what “5 stars” means or how the rating should be interpreted.

- Why: Without a short label or explanation, users cannot understand whether the stars show usefulness, danger level, or general rating. A simple caption would prevent this confusion.
- Severity: 2

Issue 6. H1 Visibility of system status

- Where: Task 2– Live Navigation page
- What: The user's current location, indicated by a small yellow dot on the map, and it is difficult to see and track against the contour lines and the blue route line.
- Why: Without a clear marker of where the user is on the route, it becomes hard to understand progress. The current location pointer could be larger, more distinctly colored, for example a brighter color, arrow, or a person icon.
- Severity: 3

Issue 7. H10 Help and documentation

- Where: Task 3 – Add comment page
- What: The “important level” section shows three colored circles (blue, yellow, red), but there is no explanation of what these colors mean.
- Why: Without any label or guidance, users cannot understand how to choose a level or what each color represents. A short description or legend would prevent this confusion.
- Severity: 2

Issue 8. H4 Consistency and standards

- Where: Task 3 – Signal Comments & Add Comment
- What: One button says, “ADD comment,” but on the next page the button only says “ADD.” They’re part of the same flow, but the text on them isn’t the same.
- Why: When two similar buttons use different labels, the user may think they do different things. Using the same wording would make it clearer.
- Severity: 2

Issue 9. H4 Consistency and standards & H2 Match between system and the real world

- Where: Task 1 – Tip details page
- What: The tip details page shows a “user” icon at the top, but the content of the page is not related to user profiles or its information. It is a tip description, but it suggests something else.

- Why: Using the same “user” icon in places where it has different meanings creates inconsistency and may confuse users about what the icon represents. Keeping icons aligned with their actual function would make the interface clearer.
- Severity: 2

Issue10. H10 Help and documentation

- Where: Task 3 – Add Comment page
- What: The “+” button on the Add Comment page has no label or explanation, and it is not clear what action it performs. It could mean adding an image, a file, or something else, but the interface does not specify.
- Why: Without any text or hint, the user has to guess the purpose of the “+” icon, which makes the action unclear. A small label would solve this issue easily.
- Severity: 2

Part V: Summary and Recommendations

Report in the table below the total number of identified violations.

Heuristic	# violations
H1: Visibility of system status	3
H2: Match between system and the real world	2

H3: User control and freedom	1
H4: Consistency and standards	2
H5: Error prevention	1
H6: Recognition rather than recall	0
H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use	0
H8: Aesthetic and minimalist design	1
H9: Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors	0
H10: Help and documentation	3
HN: Non-heuristic issue	0

Overall, the prototype gives a clear idea of how the main features of the hiking app are supposed to work. The flow of moving from a route to navigation and then to comments is understandable, and the screens are organized in a simple way. Some parts of the interface are a bit unclear, especially where the user expects feedback or needs to understand what the system is doing.

Most of the issues were related to unclear feedback or inconsistent visual elements. For instance, some icons didn't match their meaning very well, and the same action button appeared with different wording across pages. Although these inconsistencies don't stop the interface from working, they make users stuck and think about what each element does.

To improve this, it requires some small adjustments. Adding short labels or explanations in places where the meaning is not clear enough would help users progress more confidently. Keeping button labels consistent across screens would also make the flow smoother. Finally, making the user's position clearer during navigation would reduce confusion and make the experience feel more predictable.